



## BEFORE

In August 1846, Congressman David Wilmot introduced an amendment, or proviso, to an army appropriations bill that would have banned slavery forever in territories acquired from Mexico.

### WILMOT PROVISO

Although the Wilmot Proviso passed the U.S. House of Representatives, it **failed in the Senate**. As a result, the **future of slavery was still not settled** in the West.

### VARYING VIEWS

The political parties offered different solutions during the 1848 presidential election campaign. John C. Calhoun argued that the **Constitution protected property** (see [A Question of Union](#)), and so enslavers had the right to take slaves into the territories. Democratic nominee Lewis Cass argued that settlers should vote on the issue, while the **Whig Party tried to avoid** it and nominated Zachary Taylor, a Virginia enslaver and hero of the War with Mexico.

### ANTI-SLAVERY PARTY

The **Liberty Party** joined with anti-slavery Whigs and the **Free-Soil Party** to nominate former president Martin Van Buren for president. The Free-soil Party pledged itself to **no new slave states** and called slavery a "barbarism."

**T**he first steps to decide if the new territory should be slave or free were legislative. Illinois senator Stephen A. Douglas worked to balance the demands of the militant pro-slavery faction, led by Missouri senator David Atchison, with those Northern Democrats who were fearful of conceding too much to Southern interests. Douglas suggested that it be left to a vote in the territory. Atchison thought Douglas's plan of "popular sovereignty" was not enough and demanded the repeal of 1820's Missouri Compromise. Douglas agreed to argue for the repeal, thus opening up the West for the potential expansion of slavery.

The proposed Kansas-Nebraska Act triggered a passionate response. Since the Compromise of 1850 and the publication of Harriet Beecher Stowe's *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, Northern aversion to appeasing Southern "Slave Power" had grown.

Abraham Lincoln strongly believed slavery to be "an unqualified evil" and that no man had the right to hold another as property. He denounced both the act and Douglas in public. A former Whig, Lincoln now joined with others in the North who opposed slavery's expansion but as yet had no formal political party. This so-called